confidence as well. It also says a lot that Australian universities have been the first to take advantage of India's New Education Policy to set up establishments in the country.

As with US and Japan, a change in leadership reaffirmed in the Tokyo Quad Summit that cooperation was now proofed strongly in respect of political developments. Indeed, the enthusiasm of each successive government more than matched those of its predecessors.

INTENTIONS OVERCOME HESITATIONS

In assessing the Indo-Pacific, there are also dimensions that are autonomous of such bilateral matters, as indeed of the Quad. Prominent among them is the IPOI, announced by PM Modi in 2019 at the East Asia Summit. This is envisaged as an open, non-treaty-based, inclusive platform for cooperation in the region. Structure-light and cooperation-heavy, it is intended to work in tandem with other mechanisms like the ASEAN, IORA, BIMSTEC, IOC, PIF, etc. Its seven pillars include maritime security, maritime ecology; maritime resources; capacity building and resource sharing; disaster risk reduction and management; science, technology and academic cooperation; and trade connectivity and maritime transport. So far, Australia has agreed to lead the maritime ecology pillar, Japan the connectivity one, France and Indonesia the maritime resources, Singapore the science and technology one, and the UK the maritime security pillar.

How the IPOI will develop remains to be seen. But it is certainly an example of fresh thinking on regional partnerships that has the potential to move cooperation in the Indo-Pacific forward. That ASEAN, the EU and individual nations have all tabled their own outlook, vision and approaches augurs well for the future. It is also an interesting thought that as India's global footprint steadily grows, it intersects with the interests of its Quad partners. A telling case is that of India's engagement with the Pacific Island nations. Relationships between like-minded countries tend to be naturally supportive beyond the confines of their actual interaction. And the complex challenges of the contemporary world certainly can use more effective international cooperation.

India is establishing IT labs in these Pacific Island societies and promoting solar electrification. Women solar engineers called Solar Mamas have also been trained. Apart from climate-related projects, Indian grant